two countries.[1]

For India, its relationship with Russia is still important, but mainly as a source of certain categories of high-end defence technologies, such as nuclear submarines and the S-400 air defence system. But while the Sino-Russian partnership has been on an ascendant curve since the end of the Cold War, Indo-Russian relations have been on a steady decline. China and Russia have a convergent view of the evolving international situation which differs from India's. India is part of the 'Quad' with the US, Australia and Japan. Both China and Russia reject the Quad as an 'Asian NATO'. China is much more exposed to risk than India on account of the Ukraine war because of its virtual alliance with Russia.

The US has declared in unambiguous terms that any attempt by any country to help Russia evade economic sanctions would lead to secondary sanctions against that country. What has become painfully clear is that whatever may be the perception of the relative decline in US and Western power generally, their dominance of the world's financial system and currency markets provides them with unmatched leverage in a densely interconnected and networked global marketplace. This is the painful lesson which Russia is learning. This is the ominous threat that hangs over China, which has been warned explicitly that it would suffer serious consequences if it assists Russia in any way to mitigate Western sanctions. However, the West's decoupling with Russia was relatively easy, since the latter was only peripherally connected to the global economy, except in the energy and resources trade. Chinese connections with Russia are denser and far more extensive. Disruptions to these connections will spawn damage all round and will therefore not be lightly considered. China has opposed the sanctions against Russia as a matter of principle, but in practice it is likely to comply with them wherever Chinese interests are closely tied with Western entities. For example, Chinese companies have declined to provide spare parts and maintenance services to Airbus and Boeing aircraft in Russia's commercial transport fleet, which has been grounded after support services were withdrawn by the European and US aircraft manufacturers. China has a very large number of these aircraft and also has servicing